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Jim Galloway

Saxophonist Jim Galloway was born in Kilwinning, Scotland on July 28, 1936. He embraced the sound of jazz coming to Scotland via records and radio and performed in and around Glasgow before immigrating to Toronto in 1964. He has become one of the top jazz artists in Canada, performing with the Metro Stompers, the Wee Big Band, and with his own small ensembles. Jim has developed a special relationship with Jay McShann and regularly brings him to Toronto to perform.

Jim was interviewed in San Diego, California on February 15, 1998, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we're filming in San Diego, California for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. I'm pleased to have a saxophonist from overseas, and welcome Jim Galloway.

JG: Thank you, Monk.

MR: It's a pleasure to have you here and I enjoyed your playing for the last couple of days.

JG: Yeah, we've been having some fun.

MR: Yeah. There's been some swinging sets down there. Enjoyed seeing that little curved soprano.

JG: Yep. My baby.

MR: Yeah. Why the curved and not the straight?

JG: Well I have both. I have a very lovely straight soprano, a nice old Conn. I prefer most of the time to use the curved horn because, probably because of the fact that it is curved, it changes the tonal quality of the horn. It's a mellower tone than the straight horn, which can be a little nasal in its quality, and it's a little more saxophone sounding.

MR: It projects surprisingly well for its mellowness, because I could hear it from the back of the room down there.

JG: Yeah, it cuts through quite well.

MR: It's a little easier to carry around too, I think, on the planes?

JG: Just a little bit.

MR: You can set it right in your lap.

JG: Yeah, it goes everywhere.

MR: Is it an old instrument?

JG: Yes. It's a 1924 Conn.

MR: Is it low pitched by any chance?

JG: Oh yeah. It's low pitched. And I've tried some of the new horns, which have great facility, they're very fast, this one's a little slower.

MR: It's got more experience.

JG: That's right. And it's got a tonal quality to the old horns that you'll find most prefer.

MR: Well it especially fits the music.

JG: Yeah.

MR: You're from Scotland, and I don't know if I can pronounce — I'll try — Kilwinning?

JG: Well yeah. I was only there very briefly. I was born there in a nursing home. But my home and where I grew up was a little town four miles from there called Dalry, and that's where I grew up before I moved into Glasgow when I was a student.

MR: Okay. You probably know Joe Temperley.

JG: Yes indeed. Oh yes.

MR: What was the music like that you heard as a youth? Do you remember specific —

JG: Oh I remember a great deal of it because I was born in 1936, so by the time I was becoming conscious of music the war was just over, but the American Forces Network was going strong in Europe, and so I tuned in — the radio was THE thing. I lived for the radio, because that's of course where I first heard jazz. And there was quite a bit of it on BBC, played of course by local bands, some of which were pretty good. But I had the huge advantage of being able to tune in the American Forces Network. And there was, in particular, now I never have known what happened to this guy, I remember his name, he was on late every night out of Frankfurt, his name was Joe Neidig. His theme song was Artie Shaw's "Nightmare," and he played a lot of really good music. And so I cut my teeth on a lot of stuff that way.

MR: This man was a D.J., not a band leader.

JG: Yeah. No he was a D.J. It was amazing because a daunting sort of task he must have had every day, because he would have conversations between the record that he played, he'd maybe play a conversation out of a radio drama, it might be "The Whistler," and he would have a conversation with tape. It must have taken him all day, because in those days it was slicing with a razor blade, right, to edit tape. It was great, it was great, it was a lot of fun. And then of course I also was able to tune in the Voice of America with Willis Conover and that's where I heard a huge amount of the great jazz that I became so familiar with. And it was funny later on once I'd moved to Toronto, one year I did a show for, there is an event there once a year called Caravan and each nation takes a pavilion and they put on various things, and one year the American Embassy put on a pavilion and they engaged me to do the music, and it was very jazz oriented, and the lady who was in charge of it, who was at that time with the U.S. American Embassy in Toronto, had been Willis Conover's secretary. I can't believe this.

MR: Wow. You came all the way over here.

JG: So my early influences were the radio, and everything from Louis Armstrong to Charlie Parker, I listened to it all. So I developed very catholic tastes at a very early age because I was fortunate that I had — well we bought a new radio and I managed to get the old one in my bedroom. And so at a very early age, when I was supposed to be sleeping, I had the jazz with Willis Conover on, lying there in the dark, listening to all this.

MR: Yeah. I can relate to that. I've heard those—

JG: To this day I don't sleep a lot.

MR: Wow. And was the saxophone your first instrument of choice?

JG: Clarinet. And that came purely by accident. One of my pals in Dalry, I was in his home one day and they had a tremendous collection of musical instruments all over the place. And he happened to say, "Would you like to borrow a clarinet?" And I said, "Sure, I'd love to." If he had said trombone I would have tried the trombone. So that's how it all began.

MR: Cool. What playing — you moved to Canada in what year?

JG: 1964. On the 4th of July, 1964.

MR: That's a date to remember.

JG: It's a sort of personal statement.

MR: You must have done a certain amount of playing in Scotland before you came over here.

JG: Oh yeah, yeah, I did a lot of playing.

MR: Was it in small groups or big bands?

JG: No it was small groups. Small groups. I played, I mean in the late 50s, jazz had a huge revival over there, it was on the charts. I mean there was all kinds of traditionally-oriented music that was hit parade music, so there was quite a lot of work. And well I played mostly around the Glasgow area, and with a lot of different groups. And the styles of the band were pretty traditional, although at one time I went to art school in Glasgow, and while I was in art school I had this quintet, with a very close friend of mine who went to art school with me, his name was Andy Park, he ended up in television. But this quintet, it was baritone, trombone, piano, bass, drums, and we played Monk music, Thelonious Monk tunes.

MR: No kidding.

JG: Yeah. So as I say I've always had a very sort of broad acceptance of the music. And nowadays in my leisure time I listen a lot to classical, because it's another aspect of music.

MR: So were you playing — still in Scotland now — was it for dances or jazz clubs?

JG: Both.

MR: Both.

JG: Glasgow at that time was dance crazy. There were I don't know how many dance halls going five, six nights a week in Glasgow at that time. I knew that there was employment for four or five big bands, six nights a week.

MR: Wow.

JG: And then of course the onslaught of television killed it, as it's done to stuff all over the place.

MR: The dancing they were doing, was it the dances of — let me rephrase the question — were they doing the lindy hop and all that kind of stuff or was it more—

JG: Most of it was pretty straight ahead sort of body contact dancing, old fashioned dancing. And there were always a few people, especially in a jazz club, who would be into doing some jitterbug dancing.

MR: Okay.

JG: And I've never minded that, because the music is essentially a communication with people. And in its origins a lot of people danced to the music. So it's never been a problem for me to have people dancing.

MR: Yeah. Sometimes it helps. You can see what they respond to and shift your tempos to really get the thing happening. So early 60s, was the decision to come over here a long one? Was it something that you thought about for a long time?

JG: Oh I guess I did, it's hard to recall. I obviously didn't just wake up one morning and say well I'm going to Canada. I thought about it, and a lot of people have said why Toronto? And to put it all in perspective, in the mid-60s if you had a half decent education and if you were qualified in some sort of acceptable profession, and you see I had a degree from an art school, as a jazz musician they might not have wanted me, but I had this funny little piece of paper. Anyway in the mid-60s they welcomed people such as myself with open arms. It was more difficult, as it still is, to get entry into the United States. And Toronto seemed like a good spot because it was essentially still a strong British influence and it was real close to New York. So boom, Toronto it was.

MR: Cool. Was it any kind of culture shock at all or was it fairly—

JG: Oh yeah, a little bit, a little bit. The first shock was the very first night I arrived. Again, at that time in Glasgow for example, you didn't go into a bar to hear jazz. They didn't have music in bars as they have here. And so on my first night in Toronto I was on Yonge Street which is the main drag, and there's this place I see called the Colonial Tavern. And so I go in there and I literally stopped in my tracks because on the bandstand there was Vic Dickinson, Buster Bailey, Herman Autrey, Red Richards on piano — I thought I'd died and gone to heaven. So that was my first shock.

MR: That was a pretty good affirmation of your decision though I guess. Hey, I did the right thing.

JG: Yeah. And subsequently — I never worked with Buster, he died shortly after that — but I became very good friends with Vic Dickinson, I'm still a good friend of Red Richards, Herman I've played with, he's unfortunately, well like most of them departed. But Vic was a very huge influence on me. And I find that a lot of my influences have not necessarily been reed players.

MR: Have not been, pardon?

JG: Reed players all the time. I learned a huge amount about the business just playing beside people like Vic Dickinson and Bobby Hackett for example.

MR: So Toronto was a stop for those guys on their criss-crossing of the country.

JG: Yeah, at that time there was a reasonable circuit, and clubs could still afford to bring in groups. Travel wasn't as horrendously expensive as it's become, and there were traveling groups. And The Colonial and the Town Tavern were the two spots in Toronto in those days that brought in musicians. And I saw a huge procession of great players who would come through the town. Toronto always was a very good jazz town, still is.

MR: They have a big festival up there every year, don't they?

JG: Yeah.

MR: Did you employ your art degree in Toronto?

JG: Yeah. Sure. I worked as a designer initially because in those days I had been a member of the musician's union in Britain. In those days I didn't know this, but I went to the Local and said I was a member of the MU and I'd come to Canada and I'd like to transfer and join the local in Toronto. And I'll never forget the secretary/treasurer of the Local at that time was Michael Walter Murdock, another Scot, and he told me to bugger off and come back in a year.

MR: Did he really?

JG: Because you had to have a year's residence to become a member. So of course I did play, but sort of under the table gigs.

MR: That's even worse than in New York, I think it was six months.

JG: Yeah. And it's changed now, I mean it's much easier now I think.

MR: He told you to bugger off, huh?

JG: Yeah. Well actually he put it even more strongly than that.

MR: Gee.

JG: Yeah, my jaw dropped. But just his way.

MR: Just doing the union job. Wow. So how did you establish yourself as a player in Toronto?

JG: I sat in with a lot of groups, then started getting calls for gigs. And three years after I'd been there I formed a little group of my own and gosh it's been downhill from there.

MR: How long did you keep up your art work?

JG: Oh let's see now, I guess I was on the road the first time full time in the late 60s. In the early 70s there was a bit of a nose dive for music, and I went back to my art background and was sort of combining that and playing, and then a couple of years, three years or so after that I went back into it full time and it's been like that ever since.

MR: How did you go about meeting these wonderful fellas, Buddy Tate and Jay McShann and—

JG: Well Buddy I met for the first time when he was touring in Britain and he came to Glasgow in '58 and we met at a party afterwards. Jay, that came about because a club opened in '72 I think it was, called Bourbon Street, and in its first couple of years or so, or year and a half, I booked the club, and I discovered to my amazement that Jay McShann had never played Toronto. And so I met Jay simply because I phoned him and asked him if he'd like to come up to Toronto and play. And it was the beginning — the end of Casablanca when Bogart and Rains say, "This could be the beginning of a beautiful friendship" — well that's what it was, it was the beginning of a really close friendship, and Jay and I have been very, very good friends ever since.

MR: That's interesting. I'll bet it was probably neat the first time you called him and heard his voice on the phone, yeah.

JG: Yeah.

MR: That kind of Kansas City thing he has is hard to reproduce.

JG: Oh he's a one-off, man, he's it.

MR: When was the last time you got to play with him?

JG: Last summer, and well as we speak this is mid-February of '98, I'm doing a week with him the week after next.

MR: Oh great, great.

JG: So I was talking to him last week.

MR: Did you know that you have a pretty nice entry in the *Grove Dictionary*?

JG: I know there's an entry in there. I don't have the book but I know there's an entry.

MR: One thing they say is, "plays soprano sax in a lyrical style reminiscent of Sidney Bechet."

JG: Well I guess anybody who has ever decided to play soprano sax, if they're at all aware of the origins of the music, they have to have heard Bechet. He was, after all, he was the first great saxophone soloist in jazz. Statement made. And I don't think I particularly played like him, but you absorb influences and certainly he's in there. I listened a lot to him. I saw him once live, when he toured in Britain obviously before I left, and I was transfixed by his playing. The hairs on the back of my neck actually stood up, and I walked out of that concert totally changed. It was a tremendous emotional impact of his playing which you just cannot capture on record, no matter how great the records might be, just the experience of having heard him in the flesh, woah, it blew me away.

MR: Was he playing only soprano then or was he playing a clarinet at all?

JG: No he was playing soprano then. And of course a straight one.

MR: The straight one. Well that's quite a statement. Can you describe what it was about his playing that had such an emotional impact?

JG: Oh, there's an intensity to it, and actually this is interesting, his centennial was last year, and I'd been invited to New Orleans to be part of a panel discussion, and play in the street parade. And one of the things that I commented on, because I think he doesn't receive perhaps the recognition that he could have, and I think in a sense it may have been because, and this is only a little theory of mine, but when he played, he really pierced your emotions. And that can be uncomfortable for a lot of people. And I know that to me he just here, he just got right in here, and as I say, like that, and it was the intensity of his playing, he was a marvelous harmonic player, and he had a wonderful harmonic concept, and great lines. And a lot of people found that high vibrato a little difficult to take but even if you do, if you listen beyond that, what the guy was playing, it was so powerful. And I mean I had the same experience hearing Louis Armstrong. And for me just to hear Louis play a middle C, I mean it was magic. So those sort of things, they stay with you, and obviously they leave their mark. I think that emotional aspect of the music is so important. For me it's the difference between a good wine and a glass of plonk, that magic thing that was there. And the great ones have it.

MR: Who are the great ones today that have it?

JG: Well that's a hard one. Because you have to put different sort of parameters on the music. I mean it's very difficult to put people in compartments I find, but the critics in particular were very fond of creating these categories that people would fit into. But jazz has become so multi-faceted now that it's very difficult I think to define it, it's impossible to define it. There are some of the younger players that move me, and Ray Anderson moved me, one of the younger trombone players, and knows the roots of the music.

MR: I'm sorry, say it again?

JG: He knows the roots of the music. He knows its origins. And he's a very contemporary player, but to me he's full of that passion and emotion and all the magic things. And Ray does it for me. And I'm sure I could think of a bunch more. Roy Hargrove is a really great young trumpet player, and again, he's got this, it's like a fanaticism, but playing, he's got this huge passionate desire to play the horn. And I don't want to idealize that sort of thing. I don't mean to get over a message oh it's so wonderful to be able to play and it's — of course there's many other aspects to it, and the business aspect being one of them. You have to be able to take care of business. But the musicians who can do that, or who have someone who can help, but also have this magic thing going for them, they're the ones that do it for me. I could come up with a lot of — I mean on piano, I love Kenny

Barron's playing and he has a sound, and the piano is an intimate sort of — but Kenny Barron. And it would take me a little time just to —

MR: Sure, but there's still some around that really do it for you.

JG: Yeah, sure there are, of course there are.

MR: You're not one of the people who — occasionally I hear, ah, nobody's playing anything new today, nobody's got a personality on their horn today. A lot of people complain that the music schools are just turning out people who play with great abundance of technique—

JG: Yeah. And I'm one of the ones that has leveled that concern, because I'm not at all sure that, whether it be Berklee or Humber College in Toronto, there's some aspect of a production line here. And you're learning certainly how to run the changes in any key and do all sorts of things, it doesn't necessarily make you a real jazz player. Yeah, I think that's a very fair criticism.

MR: Well what are they leaving out in the education? And is it possible to show people that?

JG: Well what's left out is there's no training ground. You know you can't get your experience the same way that the early giants got it, by playing in groups here, there, everywhere, and absorbing influences from a lot of different people. You go to a college for four years and the influences you're absorbing are the ones who happen to be in that college. And great they may be, and great teachers they may be, but the broad range of experience isn't there that you absorb from all sorts of different areas.

MR: It's an unrealistic playing situation to be in without getting out in the clubs, and it's too bad that that atmosphere is not around anymore.

JG: Yes it is.

MR: Well let's listen — I just wanted to listen to a little piece of one of your recordings.

[audio interlude]

Now you managed to get Jay McShann and Jake Hanna on this record. I'm not as familiar with Fraser MacPherson.

JG: Fraser MacPherson is a marvelous tenor saxophone player who is from Vancouver. And he and I made a couple of CDs together, one with the big band and another one being a concert in Switzerland. We'd known each other for many years and unfortunately his last two recordings were the ones he did with me, and he passed on. And Jake there, Jake and Jay are buddies.

MR: Jake's a character all right.

JG: Yes indeed.

MR: Is there a big band scene still in Toronto or is it kind of an effort to mount every performance?

JG: It's tough to get the bands playing because of the practical aspect of it. It's more difficult, it's more expensive to hire seventeen pieces, but there are, in Toronto, several really good big bands. There's Boss Brass of course which comes from there, and at the other end of the spectrum playing in this style is my own band, but in between there's Dave McMurdo has a very good band, there's quite a successful if somewhat commercial big band I attribute the Glenn Miller band, but it's getting work and there's The Spitfires, there's Brigham Phyllis big band. I mean there's half a dozen really good big bands up there. They're not all working. But I mean I rehearse the big band. We get a handful of gigs every year, and the enthusiasm is there I think.

MR: Good. These jazz parties that you come to, do they have such a thing in Canada?

JG: Not really. Not in the same way. There was one gentleman who tried for a couple of years in Toronto. It didn't quite work. The festivals seem to have a bigger impact in Canada. There are jazz festivals across the country from Halifax to Victoria, and unfortunately in a sense the jazz festival is about the only way that you can get to see some groups nowadays because of the economics. Although Toronto is very fortunate in that there's a steady stream of great musicians passing through the city, we're very lucky. There's much more activity in Toronto year round than there is anyplace else in Canada.

MR: How do you like playing with these rather — well kind of like semi-organized jam sessions, at the parties? Is it mostly enjoyable?

JG: Oh yeah. We have a pretty good time. I think it shows. And it's a relatively small circle of musicians and you establish friendships and so it becomes a pleasant social three or four days as well as musically stimulating too. So it's nice.

MR: What's in the near future for you?

JG: For me? Oh I've got some jobs around the Toronto area coming up, including as I said a week with Jay. And I've got several trips back into the States this year again. I'll be in Europe at least a couple of times, I go there after the Toronto festival to a festival in Switzerland and then back in Europe in the fall. So you know it's not bad.

MR: Do you do your own business dealings?

JG: Mostly yeah. Although if I'm doing stuff around Britain there's a lovely guy there named Brian Peerless and he looks after things for a bunch of us who are on the circuit. But really there's not the money in it for a really aggressive agent to make a living from it. The money that exists in the pop world just is not in our world. And that's not all bad, because if it were pop music it would lose something.

MR: Yes it would.

JG: But it would be nice if it were just a little healthier than it is.

MR: Yeah. And I think that if it were in the megabuck range that I don't think the musicians would be as nice people as they are either.

JG: Maybe not.

MR: I don't know. Well it's been a real pleasure talking to you.

JG: Thank you.

MR: If you had an acquaintance, let's say a nephew or something like that who was an aspiring jazz musician, and said I really want to do this for a living, what would you honestly say to that person?

JG: Well I've gone into schools quite a lot. I have a little thing that I call Jazz and the Real Jam. And I go in and talk about the music and I play and I show them how it's done, and the basic terms. I always say unless you have the passion, unless it's something you just absolutely must do, don't. And I mean that. Because you have to have that fire in your gut, otherwise the business will destroy you.

MR: Well spoken.

JG: Well I believe it.

MR: Yeah. I can't recall who it was, but someone said that jazz is like having an illness. You really have to do it.

JG: Yeah. And the highs are like nothing else you'll ever know, but enjoy those, there's an awful lot of time that's down time.

MR: Well best of luck to you in your travels, and for the rest of the festival. And I love that horn, and hope you keep it in good shape.

JG: Well I'll do my best. Yeah. I need to be good to it because it's good to me.

MR: Yeah, all right.

JG: Thanks, Monk.